IT was day three of promotions in Mumbai, but Priyanka Chopra-Jonas was still in high spirits. True, it's part and parcel of being an actor—putting up an enthusiastic face in front of the media at all times—but it also had to do with a clip she had just seen on her phone: of her one-year-old daughter, Malti Marie, taking baby steps. Priyanka's mother, Madhu, is on babysitting duty as the 40-year-old actor busies herself promoting *Citadel*, one of Amazon Prime Video's most expensive shows. It's Priyanka's first trip to India in nearly three years—she last touched down in 2019 to promote the film *The Sky is Pink*. A lot has happened since then: she started an Indian restaurant in New York, had a baby through surrogacy, and shot *Citadel*, a big-budget action spectacle that has the Russo Brothers as executive producers.

Notably, for playing Nadia Sinh, a spy agent, Priyanka got paid the same as her male co-star, Richard Madden of the *Game of Thrones* (2011-2019) and *Bodyguard* (2018—) fame. The Indian film industry still falls short of offering its female actors such fairness, she says. "That's a hundred years of Indian cinema. Many female actors have played co-leads, yet they [the men] have got like 25 times more. The difference is insane."

But it's not that Priyanka expected pay parity in what's her first web series. "I'm not someone who does the job for money," she says. "I did it twice—don't ask me for names of those films—but I knew it was never going to do well." The films indeed failed, and Priyanka learnt her lesson. For *Citadel*, she credits her agents in Hollywood, the United Talent Agency (UTA), for the deal. "I don't know if it was because Amazon Studios has a female studio head [Jennifer Salke], but they didn't put up a fight." Priyanka remembers when she got the call confirming the contract. "My whole career flashed in front of me.... I needed to sit down to understand the gravity of it." She remembers how her husband Nick Jonas popped open a bottle of champagne upon hearing the news.

One can't help but marvel at what Priyanka has accomplished in less than a decade spent abroad. She became the talk of the town when she bagged the ABC serial *Quantico* (2015-2018), one of the first shows in the US to be fronted by a South Asian Indian actor. *Quantico*, she says, nudged "filmmakers to think about casting Indian talent as leads". Of course, she wasn't the first Indian actor to head to the West. Aishwarya Rai and Irrfan Khan had already done several projects. But Priyanka's journey was different in that she made the US her base. "I wanted to double down on it after *Quantico* and was looking for the next thing," says Priyanka. Soon, small roles in big films—*Baywatch* (2017) and *The Matrix Resurrections* (2021)—came. "It helped me build credibility in the English-language environment."

Priyanka takes the responsibility of being a South Asian in Hollywood very seriously. "I felt isolated and alone in Hollywood for such a long time. So did so many of my South Asian colleagues.... It has taken 10 years of grinding and introducing yourself to people, making a showreel and auditioning too." But, change is here. "It's because we are demanding it. The voices are getting louder," says Priyanka. Mindy Kaling and Aziz Ansari, who wrote their own shows (*The Mindy Project*, 2012-2017; *Master of None*, 2015-2021), and Kumail Nanjiani, who co-wrote the

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**PACKING A PUNCH**
Richard Madden and Priyanka Chopra in *Citadel*